



Strings of Hope

Membership Intelligence Report

A deep-structure analysis of the community — who they are, what they want, and the cultural DNA that binds them — reconstructed from the workshops themselves.

~3.5 hrs analyzed

2 full sessions

on-device transcription

roster + theme mining

Prepared June 2026 · Sources: *Galilee Sea* workshop & the *A-minor Improv* (chord structure & ethnic) Q&A session

Teacher: Simcha Tzuf · Upper Galilee, Israel · Confidential — internal strategy use

01 Executive Summary

Strings of Hope is a small, intimate, unusually devoted **global community of lever-harpists** gathered around one charismatic teacher, Simcha Tzuf, broadcasting from a war-affected corner of the Upper Galilee. What looks on the surface like an online harp class is, structurally, a **cross-cultural sacred-music circle** in which music theory is taught as a spiritual and emotional practice, and belonging is as much the product as the songs.

Six findings that matter most

1. **Small but deep.** ~20–25 participants per live session, with a tight, recurring core of ~10 who drive nearly all the discussion. Engagement (questions, soloing, reflection) is exceptionally high for an online class.
2. **Wide skill range in one room.** Absolute beginners (still learning to tune) sit beside theory-hungry players and even a pedal-harpist — a richness and a friction at once.
3. **Improvisation is the loudest demand.** It topped the members' own poll, and the curriculum is visibly pivoting toward **chord-based and ethnic/modal improvisation** — co-designed with members.
4. **The community's DNA is spiritual, cross-cultural and resilient.** Jewish, Sufi, Middle-Eastern and Western traditions braid together; beauty is framed as “what the world needs” against a backdrop of war and lost livelihoods.
5. **The teacher is the product.** Warmth, a Socratic “answer-a-question-with-a-question” style, and “feel it before you understand it” pedagogy create unusual loyalty.
6. **The frictions are fixable.** Theory pacing, harp-tuning literacy and recording/audio gaps are the three recurring pain points — each addressable with onboarding, tooling and capture fixes.

Method: Both sessions were transcribed in full on-device, then mined for who speaks, what they ask, skill and equipment signals, geography, and recurring themes. Names are drawn from gallery labels and how the teacher addresses members. This is a qualitative, signal-based read — not a CRM export.

02 Membership Snapshot

The live room runs **~20–25 people** (Zoom galleries of 5×5 / 6×4), plus audio-only attendees. Behind it sits a larger platform membership (a Circle community with sheet music, song libraries, replays and resource PDFs). The visible character: predominantly **mature, largely female, devoted hobbyist-to-serious players**, geographically scattered across an English-speaking diaspora, orbiting a teacher in Israel.

The engaged core

Member	Signature
Mary Misiaszek	Most active voice; theory-seeker ("the why lets me reapply it")
Wendy	Reflective; champions beauty & learning together
Barbara Grunewald	Drives the Middle-Eastern thread; brave soloist
Kimberly Papa	Curious; needs setup/tuning support
Dennis	Theory-fluent; plays a <i>pedal</i> harp
David	Pragmatic — rhythm & mechanics questions
Bella	Beginner; self-studying theory to keep up
Carolyn McKee	The "soul" voice — beauty as inspiration
Maraji / Miraji	Practical (fingering, audio); willing soloist
Anna	Smaller-harp adaptations

Also active: June, Susan, Daria, Evelyn, Karl Albert
(Lawrenceville, GA), Gabriella Nevitt, plus Joao as co-host/
organizer.

Geography & the diaspora

Members dial in from across the U.S. (e.g. Georgia) and beyond, while the teacher and the cultural centre of gravity sit in the **Upper Galilee** — ~4 km from the Lebanon border, near Safed/Tzfat. This **global-to-Galilee** shape is core to the brand: students aren't just learning harp, they're tethered to a place, a tradition and a story.

EQUIPMENT IS NOT UNIFORM

Players bring **26-string** and **34-string lever harps** and even a **pedal harp**, tuned to different keys. Much live time goes to bridging these differences (transposing, retuning a single string by hand, lever charts). Equipment literacy is a real determinant of who can keep up.

lever harps 26 & 34 string pedal harp 3-flat tuning
key of C / A-minor

03 What Members Want — Demand Signals

Ranked by how often and how forcefully it surfaces across both sessions (and the members' own poll):

Improvisation (flagship demand)		#1 poll
Ethnic / Middle-Eastern & modal scales		very high
Theory 101 (beginner on-ramp)		recurring
Chord charts & "street music" notation		high
Practice aids: sing-along notes, loops, simplified		high
Pentatonic & composing		rising

Song continuations & solo arrangements



steady

In-person Israel retreat



aspirational

Notably, the curriculum is **co-designed with members** — topics are pulled from questions members post in advance, and polls set direction. The community expects to shape what it learns.

04 Deep Structure — the Community's DNA

Beneath “harp lessons”, three intertwined threads explain why this community coheres and what it is really selling.

1 · Theory as feeling, not formula

Modes are taught as *emotional colours and identities*, not arithmetic. The guiding philosophy — repeated by teacher and members alike — is that you come to know music **by doing and feeling it** first, understanding later.

“You don't have to understand it to do it ... you're getting it in your body, and then it might suddenly hit — oh, I get it now.”

2 · Cross-cultural sacred music

A single session moves through **Jewish** (Ahava Rabbah, “the great love”), **Sufi/Turkish** (the Zirgu Leili, a whirling-dervish song; *maqam*), **Arab/Middle-Eastern** improvisation forms (*taksim*, “harp-whispering”), with nods to **Indian raga** and **Western** theory. This musical pluralism mirrors the teacher's home — a Galilee where Christians, Armenians, Muslims, Jews and Druze live side by side. **Unity through beauty** is the implicit creed.

3 · Beauty, resilience & belonging

The work is framed against war: lost gigs, a livelihood nearly gone, a border 4 km away. Members respond by treating beauty as a moral act and the class as a refuge. They explicitly value **being together, in real time** over solo replays. The name is the thesis: *strings of hope*.

“Something so beautiful that touches one's soul is a source of inspiration ... I think beauty is a huge part of what we're bringing to this instrument, and what the world needs.” — a member

05 Curriculum Evolution & Pedagogical Signature

A live pivot toward improvisation

The two sessions capture a turning point. In the *Galilee Sea* workshop the teacher announces a breakthrough: improvising is **“not about the melody — it’s the left hand and the chords.”** The very next session (the Q&A) is that idea in action: A-minor improvisation built on chord structure, ethnic modes and the pentatonic. The arc is from **teaching fixed songs** → **teaching the generative system** (chords, modes, feel) that lets members create their own.

How he teaches (and why it lands)

- Answers a question **with a question** (Socratic; “the traditional method”)
- **Feel first, understand later** — embodied learning
- Always gives the **“why”** so members self-apply
- **Low-pressure participation** — “no peer pressure”; invitational solo turns (*taksim*)
- Multi-modal aids: drone, looper, slides, sung note-names, chord charts

06 Frictions & Risks

Friction	What it looks like	Who it hits
Theory pacing	“The theory went over my head”; teacher admits he “got swept away”	Beginners (Bella); risks losing newer members
Harp setup literacy	Mistuned harps, unregulated levers, retuning live	Newer players; eats live time for all
Equipment mismatch	26 vs 34-string vs pedal; transposing on the fly	Small-harp owners
Tech & capture	Audio delay; participants un-recorded; feedback loops	Everyone — degrades replays (the gap this project fixed)
One-room, many-levels	Advanced hunger vs beginner overwhelm in the same hour	Both ends of the spectrum

07 Strategic Recommendations

- 1 **Make Improvisation the flagship program.** It is the #1 member demand *and* the teacher’s deepest passion. Build a named, progressive path (chord-based → modal/ethnic → pentatonic → composing) rather than scattered one-offs.
- 2 **Add a “First Steps / Theory 101” on-ramp.** Already requested repeatedly. A parallel beginner track (tuning, levers, major/minor, what a chord is) relieves the pacing tension and protects retention of newer members.
- 3 **Standardise harp setup & tuning onboarding.** Per-key lever charts, tuning presets and a short “set up your harp” module would reclaim live time and reduce the biggest beginner friction.

- 4 **Productise the theory.** The existing PDFs, chord/“street-music” charts, sung-note loops and modes material are begging to become tools — a modes/companion app, a searchable chord-chart library, and play-along loops. High leverage on assets that already exist.
- 5 **Fix the capture pipeline.** Use Zoom *cloud* active-speaker recording + an audio-only backup so replays both *show and hear* whoever is speaking or soloing. (Directly addresses the recurring recording gap.)
- 6 **Lean into the identity.** The cross-cultural sacred-music angle and the Galilee/resilience story are rare, ownable brand assets. Feature them in marketing, the membership platform, and especially the planned **in-person retreat** — the natural apex of a community that values being together.
- 7 **Activate the core.** The ~10 highly-engaged members are latent mentors and community leaders. Light structure (buddy practice, member solos, “ask-me” threads) compounds the loyalty that already exists.

One-line read: A small, fiercely loyal, globally-scattered circle of harpists is being taught, by a gifted teacher in a war-touched Galilee, to *improvise and feel* music across cultures — and is asking, clearly, for more improvisation, a gentler on-ramp, and tools to practise between sessions.